

which in turn displays the view the user is looking for. Sounds simple enough. A simple concept, but fail to grasp it and all of your code will be for nothing.

Let's just look at one small example of benefits of routing- the easy URL. Taking an example of an e-commerce site, if the user is on apparels page, the URL might read as www.onlinestore.com/apparels.aspx (this is a fake website: any resemblance to any live or otherwise website is purely coincidental). This is the traditional routing in a web application where the URL maps to some specific physical file mapped to a directory on the web server. Now as the user refines the categories further like shirts, t-shirts, jeans etc., the URL appends a unique ID to the previous URL so it becomes www.onlinestore.com/apparels.aspx/?catId=4. Every product category page is mapped to a unique ID which shows on the URL. An MVC routing function changes the URL to simply read as www.onlinestore.com/apparels/products/shirts. An easy to remember URL which the user can type in directly into the address bar (we know the chances of that happening are slim, this was just an example to show one benefit of routing).

So in an MVC framework like Laravel, routing does not map to a physical directory but to a controller class which executes a specific action. So without routing, the application just won't work.

At this point, if you are asking what on earth is a controller, congratulations! You are asking the right questions. We will cover that later in detail, at this point suffice to say that the controller directs the traffic between the application's core data or the universe of the data present in the application known as Model and the view shown to the user via the user interface known as the View. It decides which data is to be extracted and in what form is it to be displayed.

All Laravel routes are defined in your route files, which are located in the routes directory which are automatically loaded by the framework. There are preset files that define the routes for certain groups. E.g.

routes/web.php defines the web middleware group

routes/api.php are assigned to the api middleware group.

The routes for the web interface are defined through the routes/web.php file and provide features like session state and CSRF protection. This is the starting point for most web applications where you begin to define the routes. These can be accessed by entering the defined route's URL in your browser. For example, if you navigate to <http://your-app.test/user> in your